Black Girls Are from the Future: Afrofuturist Feminism in Octavia E. Butler's *Fledgling*

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Vampires are a ubiquitous presence in contemporary American culture. The recent popularity of *Buffy the Vampire Slayer*, the Twilight Saga, Anne Rice's *Vampire Chronicles*, the *Underworld* films, and HBO's *True Blood*, among other works, not only reflects how saturated popular culture is with vampires but also the enduring importance of these figures. Today's vampires, whether they are bloodthirsty killers or brooding romantic heroes, are as seductive to the public imaginary as were their nineteenth-century counterparts and often represent both an enchanted escape from our understood reality and a commentary thereof. Previous manifestations of the vampire phenomenon reflected, for example, xenophobic concerns about foreign contagion or the horrors of same-sex desire, among other things. Contemporary iterations, however, often underscore some of the anxieties mainstream culture has with our current multicultural and "postracial" society by seeking to "reinstate" the supremacy of whiteness, often through such tropes as the triumph of a lily-white vampire slayer or through nostalgia for an all-powerful white man who is a vampire.

Vampire texts by people of color are often invested in significantly different cultural projects, ones that more often than not trouble normative notions of race, fantasy, and power that vampires so often represent in dominant popular discourse. To that end, this essay argues that black women's vampire fiction challenges conventional tropes in contemporary vampire lore in a way that suggests a concerted literary tradition in African American speculative fiction. Using Octavia E. Butler's *Fledgling* (2005a) as a representative text, I contend that the novel offers a black feminist Afrofuturist epistemology that transgressively revises the contemporary

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vampire genre by reconfiguring the trope of the vampire from enchanted icon of whiteness to consider how race, sexuality, and intimacy can function in potentially progressive ways. *Fledgling* radically reimagines identity, kinship, and intimacy through nonmonogamous queer human-vampire hybrid families that have a variety of configurations, yet it also troubles any easy notions of a vampire utopia by ambivalently regarding the concepts of free will and symbiosis. Furthermore, Butler imagines that vampires are vulnerable to constraints similar to those faced by people in communities that are marginalized because race, gender, sexual orientation, and ability. Thus, I argue that the Afrofuturist feminism of the text illuminates epistemologies that do not suggest utopian panaceas but instead underscore the importance of transgressive manifestations of family and intimacy, epistemologies that ultimately present possibilities for our own decidedly unenchanted world.

The Rise of an Enchanted Icon

The vampire, commonly understood as a preternatural being that survives by consuming blood and has heightened powers of enchantment, or the ability to attract, enthrall, and even control others, has had a prominent place as an icon in human cultures across the world for several centuries. While vampires come in a variety of forms—such as the adze of West Africa, the *krasue* of Southeast Asia, the *soucouyant* of the Caribbean, and the undead of eastern European tradition—they are all connected by their powers of enchantment.[1] As J. M. Tyree notes, "Classically, being under the spell of a vampire involves effacement by seduction into an exploitative relationship between an omnisexual seducer and a parade of slave lovers—male and female—who are viewed as both interchangeable parts and as natural resources or blood banks" (2009, 31). Vampires have existed as a mainstay in folklore across the world for centuries but would not become popular literary figures in the West until the nineteenth century. Works such as John Polidori's short story "The Vampyre" (1819) and J. Sheridan Le Fanu's lesbian vampire novella *Carmilla* (1872) consider the allures and anxieties of homoerotic desire and intimacy in homosocial friendship via an enchanting "friend-seeking" vampire (Auerbach 1997, 11).[2] Dracula is perhaps the most (in)famous of all nineteenth-century vampires. Bram Stoker's 1897 novel depicts the vampire figure as the exemplification of the eastern European debauchery and excess that seemed to threaten the

supremacy of Western civilization. Jules Zanger asserts, "In Stoker's novel, Dracula is presented to the reader as the earthly embodiment of supernal Evil. . . . Dracula, for Stoker and for Stoker's readers is the Anti-Christ" (1997, 18). Ultimately, Dracula was perhaps most dangerous because of his unabashed (and unnatural) sexuality, sexual prowess, and powers of enchantment, for as Margaret L. Carter suggests, "Count Dracula gives his victims sexual experiences which the male heroes of the novel cannot match" (1997, 28). *Dracula*, then, can be understood as a cautionary tale that uses the figure of the enchanting vampire to warn against the allure of unbridled exogamy and lust[3] Popularity in vampires increased throughout the twentieth century and has particularly mushroomed in the past thirty years or so. While vampires of the current cultural moment are certainly indebted to their forbearers, it is clear that, as Joan Gordon and Veronica Hollinger insist, "since the mid-1970s . . . the figure of the vampire has undergone a variety of fascinating transformations in response, at least in part, to ongoing transformations in the broader cultural and political mise-en-scène" (1997, 1). This shift is not a new phenomenon. Just as Bram Stoker's *Dracula* betrayed a Victorian anxiety about the encroaching Other, so do many twenty-first-century vampire texts reveal particular contemporary interests and concerns.

Although contemporary vampire fiction, film, and television covers a wide range of subjects, among the most popular, the series *Buffy the Vampire Slayer* and the Twilight Saga (both the films and novels), arguably reflect much of the most current dominant vampire ethos. At the heart of both series, one avowedly liberal, the other unabashedly conservative, is the valorization of whiteness and, in the latter, white masculinity, in particular. *Buffy*, a campy production starring a strong and spirited white heroine and her friends, takes place in the archetypal suburb of Sunnydale, California. While Neal King calls *Buffy* "merrily racist," citing the series' predilection for killing otherworldly creatures without remorse in order to eradicate difference, one need only look at the show's composition and guest stars to see that while Sunnydale High may have been creator Joss Whedon's attempt at correlating high school with hell, his critique rarely acknowledges race or racism as a potential factor in high school's hellishness (King 2003, 199). Almost all the main and supporting characters in the *Buffy* universe are white—even vampires generally appear in an exaggerated type of "whiteface," for as Ewan Kirkland notes, "despite exceptions, *Buffy's* whiteness characterizes both heroes and villains. The generic vampires, demon

gangs, and villainous Sunnydale residents constitute a predominantly white challenge for the series' white protagonists" (2005, para. 18). Characters that might challenge the show's overwhelming WASPiness, such as Buffy's sidekick Willow Rosenberg, are devoid of any racial or ethnic difference.[4] However, as King suggests, when race is acknowledged in *Buffy* it is often with unfortunate results. Take, for instance, the two-episode arc "What's My Line," parts 1 and 2, where another slayer appears, much to Buffy's chagrin. The new slayer, Kendra Young, is of African descent and, like most of *Buffy's* characters of color, is promptly disposed of at the second episode's end. Unlike Buffy, who is somewhat of a rogue fighter with a keen sense of her own intelligence and physical prowess, Kendra follows orders and is completely obedient to her superiors, a fact that does not allow her to think for herself and ultimately gets her killed. The series-long anxiety with race in *Buffy* makes this brief inclusion of Kendra Young both intriguing and problematic. As Kent A. Ono insists, "In contrast to blonde Buffy, Kendra's presence seems to pose a threat to the uniqueness of Buffy, to her whiteness, and perhaps her individuality. The fact that Kendra is a woman of color who ultimately and unexpectedly has her throat slit is just one more instance of a woman (of color) who cannot be a hero" (2000, 174). In the end, despite *Buffy*'s self-avowed proclamation of girl power, the series largely succeeds in reifying the supremacy of whiteness in both vampire lore and our contemporary world.

In the case of the Twilight series, penned by Mormon author Stephenie Meyer, the "gender ideology is ultimately and unapologetically patriarchal" and, thus, the romantic (and very pale) vampire hero of the series, Edward Cullen, is unabashedly paternalistic and unyielding (Silver 2010, 122). Edward is consistently carrying, driving, or ordering about the novel's heroine, Bella Swan. J. M. Tyree identifies Edward as a "new combination of undead chum and unnaturally attentive lover, a sort of guardian angel with fangs . . . willing to 'wait for the right moment' rather than forcing the issue of sexual congress" (2009, 32). Edward's beauty is described incessantly, with frequent reference to his devastatingly handsome whiteness. He is "heavenly" (Meyer 2005, 107), with a "perfect nose" and "flawless lips" (277), and "his skin, white despite the faint flush from yesterday's hunting trip, literally sparkled, like thousands of tiny diamonds were embedded in the surface" (260). While Meyer's sparkly bloodsuckers may be met with derision from vampire purists, Edward Cullen's dazzling, enchanting whiteness should not, and indeed cannot, be ignored.

While Edward is the epitome of chivalry and self-control, his rival for the attentions of Bella Swan, Jacob Black, an indigenous young werewolf, is literally an uncontrollable animal. Meyer relies on racist tropes of rational whiteness versus noble savagery of indigenous peoples in her depictions of Bella's suitors. Although Bella loves both men, in the end she marries the white patriarch that will give her a stable (albeit undead) family. If, as Nina Auerbach insists, every age "gets the vampires it deserves" what does Stephenie Meyer's conservative white vampire mythos reveal about this contemporary moment? One thing it certainly reveals is that the yearning for the "comforts" of heteropatriarchy are alive and well (or perhaps undead and well) and that, yet again, speculative fiction serves as an ideal vehicle for disseminating a vision of the future that looks startlingly like the past.

Ultimately, although *Buffy* and *Twilight* are strikingly different in tone and content, they are just two examples of recent vampire works that either implicitly or explicitly state that the fictional world of vampires is a space where the supremacy of whiteness reigns unchallenged.[5] Both *Buffy* and *Twilight* reflect what Richard Dyer has cited as a primary definition of whiteness, which is to function the "human norm" (1997, 2). Dyer insists that in "Western representation whites are overwhelminging and disproportionately predominant, have the central and elaborated roles, and above all placed as the norm, the ordinary, the standard" (3). Contemporary iterations of vampire cosmology such as *Buffy* and *Twilight*—and even the avowedly transgressive *True Blood* series—illustrate a preoccupation with an idealized whiteness that oftentimes diminishes or even erases people of color and the possibility of a future in which whites are not the primary power holders. I would contend that such contemporary vampire works enact what Patricia Hill Collins has identified as notions of hegemonic binary thinking that thrive on simplistic oppositional categories such as "white/black, man/woman, heterosexual/homosexual, saint/sinner, reason/emotion, and normal/deviant" (2005, 349). Invariably, categories on the "wrong" side of the binary in *Buffy, Twilight,* and other popular depictions of vampires speak to fantasies of and anxieties around whiteness, seeking to crystallize and affirm whiteness, which is seemingly under siege by the ever-encroaching presence of historically marginalized peoples.

Despite the apparently overwhelming presence of white vampires and slayers in contemporary popular culture and literature, there have been works of fiction and film that prominently feature people of color and

that, not surprisingly, have a rather different take on the function of the vampire. Although the films *Ganja and Hess* (1972) and *Blacula* (and its 1973 sequel, *Scream, Blacula, Scream*!) have largely been dismissed, Frances Gateward persuasively insists that they interrogate race in interesting ways and should not be overlooked (2004, para. 7). Later films such as *Def by Temptation* (1990), the *Blade* trilogy (1998, 2002, 2004), and *Vampire in Brooklyn* (1995) portray African Americans in vampire story lines, with varying results. Generally, these films do not function as vehicles to reify whiteness as a mythical ideal; instead, they use the vampire trope to consider issues such as the legacy of slavery (*Blacula*) or as a cautionary tale about "deviant" sexuality (*Def by Temptation*). I would argue, however, that some of the most transgressive vampire narratives have occurred in black women's literature.

Jewelle Gomez's 1991 novel, *The Gilda Stories,* traces the over two-hundred-year life span of the titular heroine, who is a rather atypical vampire: Gilda is an African American lesbian who becomes a vampire after her escape from slavery in 1850 and, perhaps most odd, she never terrorizes and rarely kills humans. Instead, she and her comrades feed on humans in a manner that Gomez calls an "exchange," whereby a vampire feeds on a human donor and leaves the donor with positive thoughts and messages about his or her life. Although Gilda and her vampire family have the power to kill (and sometimes do), life for them is largely about learning and reciprocity, not power and privilege, especially as they traverse hostile dystopian and eventually apocalyptic landscapes from the nineteenth to the twenty-first century. Gomez considers the implications of race, gender, sexuality, and ability within the egalitarian ethic of the exchange in several nuanced ways. Through the trope of the exchange, Gomez not only challenges traditional vampire mythology but also offers an epistemological shift concerning the ethics of intimacy and family in the face of dystopia and apocalypse. More specifically, her delineation of the exchange not only relates to how vampires nourish themselves but also illuminates a way of knowing and experiencing the world and of reconfiguring intimacy that is profoundly antiracist, anticolonialist, and feminist. Horror authors Tananarive Due's *African Immortals* series (published 1997–2011) and L. A. Banks's twelve-volume *Vampire Huntress* series (published 2003–2010) feature multiethnic vampires and vampire hunters who bear little resemblance to their mainstream counterparts and who, like Gomez, are more interested in using the vampire trope as way to consider marginalized sub-

jectivities. Likewise, speculative-fiction maven Octavia E. Butler's final novel before her death in 2006 is the vampire narrative *Fledgling*, which, like its African American speculative-fiction counterparts, is a meditation on autonomy, family, and race. Ultimately, these various texts by black women reveal a thriving speculative-fiction community that stands in stark counterpoint to many of the most popular current depictions of vampire lore.

Afrofuturist Feminism

Speculative fiction, that is, science fiction, fantasy, horror, and futurist fiction, has largely been (mis)understood as a genre written only by whites (mostly men) about whites (again, mostly men). However, by the end of the twentieth century black writers such as Samuel Delaney, Octavia E. Butler, Steven Barnes, Tananarive Due, and Nalo Hopkinson, among others, reflected a tradition of black speculative fiction known as Afrofuturism.[6] My use of the term "Afrofuturism" is particularly informed by Afrofuturist scholars Mark Dery, Alondra Nelson, Lisa Yaszek, and Kodwo Eshun. Dery coined the term "Afrofuturism" in 1994 to "describe African-American culture's appropriation of technology and SF imagery" (2008, 6). He further notes that "speculative fiction that treats African-American concerns in the context of twentieth-century technoculture and, more generally, African-American signification that appropriates images of technology and a prosthetically enhanced future . . . might, for want of a better term, be called Afro-Futurism" (8). Dery's portmanteau of "afro" and "futurism" denotes the important connection between race and futurist fiction, a circumstance that tends to go unacknowledged in mainstream speculative fiction.[7] In addition to Dery's definition, Alondra Nelson's groundbreaking work—including editing the special issue of *Social Text* devoted to Afrofuturism and founding the Afrofuturism Listserv and website—has been vital to the development of Afrofuturism criticism and scholarship. Nelson contends that Afrofuturism forwards "takes on digital culture that do not fall into the trap of the neocritics or the futurists of one hundred years past. These works represent new directions in the study of African diaspora culture that are grounded in the histories of black communities, rather than seeking to sever all connections to them" (2002, 9). Likewise, Afrofuturist scholar Lisa Yaszek suggests, "While early Afrofuturists are concerned primarily with the question of whether or not there

will be any future whatsoever for people of color, contemporary Afrofuturists assume that in the future race will continue to matter to individuals and entire civilizations alike. In doing so, they expand our sense of the possible and contribute to the ongoing development of science fiction itself" (2006). My use of Afrofuturism is also informed by Kodwo Eshun's assertion that Afrofuturism is "concerned with the possibilities for intervention within the dimension of the predictive, the projected, the proleptic, the envisioned, the virtual, the anticipatory and the future conditional" (2003, 293). Furthermore, it is important to note, as Eshun contends, that "Afrofuturism may be characterized as a program for recovering the histories of counter-futures created in a century hostile to Afrodiasporic projection and as a space within which the critical work of manufacturing tools capable of intervention within the current political dispensation may be undertaken" (301). Thus, Afrofuturism is an epistemology that both examines the current problems faced by blacks and people of color more generally and critiques interpretations of the past and the future. Ultimately, Dery, Nelson, Yaszek, and Eshun illuminate that one of Afrofuturism's foremost guiding tenets is the centrality of African diasporic histories and practices in sustaining progressive visions of the future. Put another way, not only does Afrofuturism posit that blacks will exist in the future, as opposed to being harbingers of social chaos and collapse, but in "recovering the histories of counter-futures" Afrofuturism insists that blacks fundamentally *are* the future and that Afrodiasporic cultural practices are vital to imagining the continuance of human society.

Because much of Afrofuturism's transgressive politics align with the fundamental tenets of black feminist thought, I argue that it is critical to understand these epistemologies not only as related but as, in fact, in conversation with one another and potentially even symbiotic. Just as Afrofuturism underscores the centrality of blacks to futurist knowledge and cultural production and resistance to tyranny, so does black feminist thought contend that black people's experience, knowledge, and culture are vitally important. Black feminist theorist Patricia Hill Collins claims, "Black feminist thought affirms, rearticulates, and provides a vehicle for expressing in public a consciousness that quite often already exists" (2000, 32). Moreover, just as Afrofuturism seeks to liberate the possibilities that open up when blackness is linked to futurity, so does black feminist thought seek to uncouple dominance from power as blacks assert their agency, for as bell hooks declares, "Moving from silence into speech is

for the oppressed, the colonized, the exploited, and those who stand and struggle side by side a gesture of defiance that heals, that makes new life and new growth possible. It is that act of speech, of 'talking back,' that is no mere gesture of empty words, that is the expression of our movement from object to subject—the liberated voice" (1989, 9). This movement toward a liberated voice, as hooks suggests, is not about simply replacing the dominant voice with the voice of the marginalized; rather, liberation is cast in terms of coalition and power sharing, methodologies that would incite a future quite different from the hegemony of present structures. I want to consider the synthesis of Afrofuturism and black feminist thought as Afrofuturist feminism. Afrofuturist feminism is a reflection of the shared central tenets of Afrofuturism and black feminist thought and reflects a literary tradition in which people of African descent and transgressive, feminist practices born of or from across the Afrodiaspora are key to a progressive future. Ultimately, I argue that recognizing Afrofuturist feminism offers a critical epistemology that illuminates the working of black speculative fiction in vital ways.

Octavia Butler is certainly among the authors whose works exemplify Afrofuturist feminism. In her essay "Positive Obsession," Butler asserts that speculative fiction has the potential to catalyze progressive political change and that, for black people, this is a particularly significant project. She writes:

> What good is any form of literature to Black people? What good is science fiction's thinking about the present, the future, and the past? What good is its tendency to warn or to consider alternative ways of thinking and doing? What good is its examination of the possible effects of science and technology, or social organization and political direction? At its best, science fiction stimulates imagination and creativity. It gets reader and writer off the beaten track, off the narrow, narrow footpath of what "everyone" is saying, doing, thinking—whoever "everyone" happens to be this year. And what good is all this to Black people? (2005b, 135).

Butler's rhetorical questions and subsequent answers reject the notion that speculative fiction is a "whites only" enterprise, arguing instead that the genre can incite transgressive epistemologies for a variety of people. Also, Butler's emphasis on the transformative potential of speculative fiction underscores her Afrofuturist work as being defined by a feminist sensibility. That is, her works of speculative fiction not only adhere to the

tenets of Afrofuturism but also are self-consciously interested in the connections between race, gender, sexuality, and ability that are at the core of black feminist thought. Indeed, as Marilyn Mehaffy and AnaLouise Keating note, "Octavia Butler's work is thematically preoccupied with the potentiality of genetically altered bodies—hybrid multispecies and multiethnic subjectivities—for revising contemporary nationalist, racist, sexist, and homophobic attitudes" (2001, 45). Thus, Butler's work is Afrofuturist feminism in several ways. Her texts are committed to portraying complicated (and sometimes vexed) histories of people of color and visions of the future with people of color at the center, with a particular emphasis on women of color. Butler's fiction is also fundamentally interested in critiquing conventional systems of power and dominance and offering futurist solutions based on cooperation and egalitarian ethics. Thus, Butler's writing consistently advocates transgressing repressive social norms and rejecting heteropatriarchy, while centering (or creating) a variety of experiences from across the Afrodiaspora. Nonetheless, while Butler's Afrofuturist work underscores a commitment to an equitable vision of society, it does not resort to simply offering up utopias. Butler's visions of the future are often ambivalent ones that reveal an ongoing struggle for peace and justice.

To that end, while contemporary vampires (and other principle figures and tropes of speculative fiction) are often illustrated as a way to crystallize and affirm whiteness and Western values, Butler's Afrofuturist feminism radically challenges these tenets. She (re)configures vampires as powerful beings not outside of the history of racism, but as powerful, enchanting beings that are both vulnerable to the constraints of racism, sexism, homophobia, and ableism (and their attendant violence) and committed to creating futures for them and those they love that reject these ways of knowing. Nevertheless, I am not arguing that *Fledgling* is (simply) a reactionary text. As Kimberly Nichelle Brown argues, "Contemporary African American female writing is a product of choice, of agency, rather than solely a reaction to victimization" (2010, 64). In other words, I see the novel participating in a tradition of feminist resistance in literature that also taps into the potential (albeit sometimes unrealized) that speculative fiction has to interrogate and challenge normative ideologies and practice. That is not to say that Butler's Afrofuturistic vampires are not enchanted or enchanting; however, they break from many of the traditional or conventionally popular tropes. These vampires are a biological species, not

a supernatural force. Some of them are "daywalkers," or, in other words, can move about in the sun. They have preternatural strength but they are not invincible. They have seductive powers of persuasion that they largely use for good, not evil. They live in nonnormative groups with or among human beings and are (generally) not antagonistic to humans. Although not magical creatures, Butler's vampires are, nevertheless, enchanted because of the power that they wield, despite their various flaws and vulnerabilities and their ability to radically alter their surroundings and challenge normative notions of how to be.

"We have very little in common with the vampires Bram Stoker described in *Dracula*"

Butler radically reimagines notions of enchantment within the vampire genre in *Fledgling* through her illustration of the racially hybrid and matrifocal vampire species known as the Ina. Vampires in the novel are a powerful humanoid species with fierce physical and mental abilities that need to consume blood to survive. Through the notion of mutualism, a family system in which humans and vampires rely on each other for survival in a complex web of nonmonogamous, interracial intimate relationships, Butler challenges both the primacy of nuclear families and the dominance of repressive heteropatriarchal societies. More specifically, like Gomez's notion of the exchange in *The Gilda Stories*, Butler's delineation of "mutualism" is not only how vampires and humans nourish themselves within the world of the novel but also a way of knowing and experiencing the world and of reconfiguring intimacy that, in its most ideal state, is centered on cooperation, interdependence, honesty, and complex understandings of power. In *Fledgling*, mutualism not only recalibrates intimacy and family, however, but also becomes an ideal, though imperfect, futurist social model, one that is fundamentally at odds with racism, sexism, and sectarian violence. Thus, Butler challenges traditional vampire mythology's illustration of enchantment and its current iteration in dominant popular culture and also offers an Afrofuturist feminist vision that is an epistemological shift concerning the ethics of identity, intimacy, and family.

Butler recasts traditional notions of vampires and enchantment by illustrating the Ina more generally as a long-lived (though not immortal) species that predates humans. The Ina do not have magical powers; they cannot turn into bats, or fly, or glitter in the sunlight. What they do have

is a keen sense of sight and hearing, along with an acute understanding of microexpressions that allows them to discern when a person is lying.[8] Ina blood is composed of an addictive substance that does, however, allow them a great measure of control over humans. Butler writes, "We addict them to a substance in our saliva—in our venom—that floods our mouths when we feed. I've heard it called a powerful hypnotic drug. It makes them highly suggestible and deeply attached to the source of the substance. They come to need it" (2005a, 73).[9] The enchanting effects of this venom links vampires and their human companions in what is sometimes an uneasy codependency. Butler explains that the Ina's venom, and their other extraordinary senses, are biological rather than supernatural phenomena. Indeed, Marty Fink suggests that "Butler's approach to [the vampire] genre is characterized by duality and fusion, as the novel interbreeds the vampire narrative with science fiction" (2010, 428). Nevertheless, despite being illustrated as a medical fact, their venom functions not completely unlike traditional tropes of vampire powers of seduction and enchantment. Ina venom enthralls and heavily influences human behavior.

Butler's Afrofuturist feminist project in the novel, however, further troubles the categories of vampire as predator and humans as prey in several ways. Laurel Bollinger notes, "In sharp contrast to more traditional vampire novels that may eroticize the encounter between vampire and human but still envision exploitation or a predator/prey dynamic (even such otherwise-different stories as those by Anne Rice and Suzy McKee Charnas share these assumptions), Butler's vampires, called Ina, are more properly understood as existing in symbiotic relations with the humans who sustain them" (2007, 345). Butler describes the complex arrangements between Ina and their human companions, or symbionts, as "mutualistic symbiosis" or "mutualism" (2005a, 123). Simply put, these terms underscore that while the Ina are literally sustained by their symbionts' blood, the symbionts are not simply enchanted by the Ina but also benefit from this exchange. Iosif, the father of the novel's protagonist Shori, assures her first symbiont, Wright, that his "immune system will be greatly strengthened by Shori's venom, and it will be less likely to turn on you and give you one of humanity's many autoimmune diseases. And her venom will help keep your heart and circulatory system healthy. Your health is important to her" (63). In fact, symbionts can live from 170 to 200 years. Mutualism reflects the tenets of Afrofuturist feminism in that it recalibrates the traditional power dynamics in vampire lore to illuminate a pos-

sible future where negotiations of power successfully function in ways that bear little resemblance to our own patriarchal power structures.

Clearly, mutualism helps to stem some of the frailties of life for both humans and vampires; however, Butler notes that mutualism also incites complex negotiations of intimacy in other ways. Human symbionts are not simply sustenance for the Ina—they are key to their survival in other ways. The Ina need their human symbionts for food, companionship, physical touch, and sexual pleasure, although the Ina can get some of these needs met with one another. In other words, the Ina do not just require human blood from anonymous donors, they need to coexist and share intimacy with human beings (and each other) in order to survive. Joan, a female Ina elder and one of Shori's relatives, admits, "We need our symbionts more than most of them know. We need not only their blood, but physical contact with them and emotional reassurance from them. Companionship. I've never known even one of us to survive without symbionts. . . . We either weave ourselves a family of symbionts, or we die. Our bodies need theirs" (270). Thus, the power dynamics between humans and Ina are revealed to be more convoluted than they might seem at first glance. As powerful as Ina venom is, human touch and emotion rival it. Ordinary human beings, then, also have their own peculiar brand of enchantment. That is, in their own way human symbionts can also attract, enthrall, and control (albeit in a limited way) their Ina companions. This circumstance reflects an Afrofuturist feminist ethic in that it calls for a shift in our understanding of the negotiations of intimacy and power in a way that troubles normative notions of dominance.

Still, Butler never portrays mutualism as always being completely equitable. Some Ina, for example, use their superhuman powers of influence and suggestion to treat humans like pets or toys. One Ina male "was very careful of his own [symbionts], but he liked sending them among us with instructions to start trouble, raise suspicions and jealousies, start fights. He liked to watch arguments and fights. His symbionts were so good, so subtle that we didn't realize what was happening at first. It excited the hell out of him when two of Radhu's symbionts almost killed one another. He got something sexual out of watching" (131). This Ina male saw symbionts who were not his own simply as a means to fulfill his sexual fantasies without regard to their safety or well-being. Indeed, Butler writes, "The symbionts would have died if they hadn't been symbionts—but then, they never would been endangered if they hadn't been symbionts" (131). Other Ina

recognize their need for human companionship begrudgingly because they are convinced of their own superiority; one example is the Silk family, who want to eliminate human-Ina hybrids such as Shori for fear of contamination and racial "mongrelization." Racist Ina "don't like the idea that a good part of the answer to [their] daytime problems is melanin" (147). Laurel Bollinger suggests that "some symbiosis seems to be positive, an instance of mutualism, and some becomes parasitism or even destructive fusion" (2007, 332). Ultimately, life as a symbiont is greatly dependent on the ethics of the symbionts' Ina companions, a fact that illuminates some of the potential pitfalls of mutualism. Butler focuses on this malevolent side of vampire enchantment as a form or practice of power that can reify inequality, patriarchal dominance, and violence.

In line with Afrofuturist feminism's interest in the complex negotiations around power sharing, Butler also portrays symbionts struggling with their increasing codependence on their Ina companions in an attempt to complicate notions of enchantment and its influence on individual and collective power. For example, Wright particularly takes issue with his diminishing independence and his increasing desire for a monogamous relationship with Shori, despite the Ina's openly polyamorous intimate arrangements. When Shori asks him if he wants to leave their relationship, he angrily replies, "Why bother to ask me that?" adding, "I can't even really want to leave you. . . . I wish I had driven past you on the road eleven nights ago and not stopped. And yet, I know that if I could have you all to myself, I'd stop for you again, even knowing what I know about you" (Butler 2005a, 84). Wright's rage stems not only from his struggle with the allure of Shori's enchantment and his thereby decreased autonomy but also from what he perceives as the unnatural or, at the very least, inappropriate social dynamics of mutualism, with its communal living, queer pansexuality, and nonmonogamy, among other nonnormative practices. Butler repeatedly foregrounds these tensions, because Shori's subject positions disrupt traditional paradigms and her sexuality transgresses these boundaries. Not only does Shori have a sexual relationship with Wright, but she also engages in a variety of sexual acts with other men and women of varying ages and races. To be sure, queer vampires are not unusual. However, Butler's Ina are not queer simply because of their sexual practices, which are decidedly nonnormative. Butler depicts Shori and her Ina kin's notion of family and intimacy of all sorts as profoundly queer because they actively reject the trappings of heteropatriarchy at work in the larger society.

Butler ultimately leaves these tensions unresolved, underscoring Afrofuturist feminist ethics in which intimate relationships require multiple and ongoing negotiations. To that end, when Shori reveals Wright's jealousy to her father, Iosif advises her not to attempt to control her symbionts' feelings: "Talk to him. Help him. Reassure him. Stop violence. But let him feel what he feels and settle his feelings in his own way" (73). Although the Ina have powers of mind control, Iosif suggests that violent coercion, so often romanticized as a vampire's most powerful and alluring weapon, is, in the end, both unethical and ineffective. Iosif declares, "Let [your symbionts] see that you trust them and let them solve their own problems, make their own decisions. Do that and they will willingly commit their lives to you. Bully them, control them out of fear or malice or just for your own convenience, and after a while, you'll have to spend all your time thinking for them, controlling them, and stifling their resentment" (73). In this way, Butler reframes what it means for a vampire to enchant others. While Ina venom is a biological phenomenon, Butler also insists that their powers of enchantment are a social issue with varied interpersonal repercussions. By illuminating the complex negotiations required of a human-Ina relationships, Butler rejects conventional notions of vampire as predator and human as prey in order to resituate a shared (and often vexed) series of negotiations between two interconnected but distinct species. This reconfiguration is in fact an Afrofuturist feminist paradigm shift that challenges the ways in which vampire stories often devolve into thinly veiled romanticizations of patriarchy. Butler's portrayal of the at once powerful and vulnerable Ina, then, is an Afrofuturist feminist commentary on the complicated nature of power dynamics more generally.

Thus, while the Ina are long lived, living in fact for up to five hundred years, they are not immortal and they are far from invincible or infallible. Because of their appearance (tall, gaunt, and generally pale), they have been singled out by humans as foreigners in many communities and have been exterminated under xenophobic pogroms. Furthermore, they are, with the exception of human-Ina hybrids such as Shori, fatally allergic to sunlight and, like most living things, cannot withstand fire. Thus, when the bigoted Ina who fear the results of human-Ina miscegenation seek to get rid of Shori's kin, they simply set their homes on fire during the day when they are most vulnerable. While this is an extreme example of their weakness, it is important. Butler insists that being rich, powerful, and long lived does not make one completely invulnerable or above ignorance. Although

contemporary mainstream vampires are sometimes brooding or even troubled, they often operate largely outside ordinary problems of death and institutionalized discrimination. Shori, on the other hand, is heavily affected by the racist bigotry and violence enacted by the Silks: they murder all her immediate male and female kin and several times come very close to murdering her. However, as Ali Brox contends, "Butler's vampires do not embody the fears and anxieties of the society they infiltrate; rather, Butler shifts the monstrosity from the figure to the social ills themselves. . . . The Ina who attack Shori and her family are not monstrous because they are vampires, but they are monstrous because of the anti-human rhetoric they direct toward their symbionts and Shori's mixed-blood status" (2010, 396). In this way, Butler's Ina transgress conventional vampire tropes not only by being mortal but also by experiencing (and succumbing to) hierarchal divisions, such as those of racism, mirroring the violent systems of oppression that are the foundation of much of the human world. By shifting the blame from preternatural enchantment to very ordinary forms of domination, Butler also points out where the true problems are in our own unenchanted world. Butler's Afrofuturist feminist vision in *Fledgling*, then, illuminates the futurist potential in radically restructuring our conceptions of intimacy and family while also providing a cautionary tale about the ways in which culturally sanctioned practices of violence and discrimination can threaten even the most promising of futures.

Black Girls Are from the Future

In an early study of Butler's works, Ruth Salvaggio contends, "Though Butler's heroines are dangerous and powerful women, their goal is not power. They are heroines not because they conquer the world, but because they conquer the very notion of tyranny" (1984, 81).[10] This sentiment also describes the dynamics at the heart of *Fledgling*, Butler's final novel. *Fledgling* strips vampires of both their omnipotence and their universalizing whiteness. Instead, Butler insists that vampires' potential strength is not in their brawn, or speed, or seductiveness; rather, their strength can be found in symbiosis and hybridity, a transgressive Afrofuturist feminist stance dangerous to conservative notions of identity and community often found in vampire lore. De Witt Douglas Kilgore has suggested, "Black women who contribute to [science fiction/fantasy/horror] have reached the point where the history they recover can potentially become future

history. It is now possible to identify a new pattern of expectation, one that emerges from long-suppressed voices" (2008, 127). Thus, the organizing principles of Ina life have the potential to stand as a sort of Afrofuturist feminist epistemology and become a pragmatic model of cooperation that, while a work in progress, does not simply reinforce racism, sexism, and compulsory heterosexuality and other hegemonic social ideals. Furthermore, Butler's emphasis on symbiosis, enchantment, and the ways in which the novel's humans and Ina struggle to make sense of the evolution of their cultures and species reflects the challenges found in our own diverse, unenchanted world as we try to make feminist futures out of trenchant patriarchal realities.

Octavia Butler is one member of a thriving cohort of Afrofuturist feminist writers whose work is actively reconfiguring the contours of speculative fiction. Her work stands alongside of and is in conversation with the work of writers such as Jewelle Gomez, whose pioneering work in queer speculative fiction has inspired more nuanced renderings of black sexualities; Tananarive Due, whose recent work in horror has revolutionized the genre by focusing on complex black heroines; L. A. Banks, whose dark fantasy/horror novels rival Buffy's girl power but without the racist dynamics; Nalo Hopkinson, whose Afrodiasporic tales of fantasy and folklore skillfully blend tradition with a futurist vision; and Nnendi Okorafo-Mbachu, whose stories of precolonial Africa incite us to reenvision the continent's past and future. Their works stand as, in the words of Kimberly Nichelle Brown (2010), decolonizing texts that destabilize normative notions of what is possible by creating worlds in which black women not only have the power to transform their lives, communities, and even species but do so routinely and, often, unapologetically. Ultimately, while mainstream speculative fiction might depict women, and women of color, especially, as accessories or minor characters, these authors insist that black women and girls are in the present and can and do signify (on) the future.

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Notes

1. The adze, part of a tradition native to Togo and Ghana, are vampiric fireflies that kill unsuspecting sleepers. The *krasue* of Southeast Asia are floating, headless female apparitions that suck blood and devour flesh. The *soucouyant* of the Caribbean is a witchlike vampire that travels as a fireball and sucks blood from sleeping victims.
2. Nina Auerbach notes, "Until the coming of the impersonal, imperial Dracula in 1897, this friend-seeking vampire dominated the nineteenth century, although only Carmilla, a female vampire could fully realize these anti-social desires" (1997, 11). Auerbach identifies these desires as "antisocial" because they challenged and attempted to dismiss the heteronormative notions of friendship, family, and intimacy at the center of Victorian life.
3. *Dracula* has remained not only timely but also undeniably influential. William Patrick Day notes that the novel remains seminal even today, claiming, "Stoker's Dracula now serves as a synthesis of romantic, Victorian, and Christian values, ideals, and fears, allowing us to take it apart and create informing structures for our [modern] vampires" (2002, 17).
4. For an in-depth discussion of the treatment of Jewish identity in *Buffy*, see Pateman 2007.
5. Two further examples of this trope appear in the HBO series *True Blood* and in the recently published novel *A Discovery of Witches*, by Deborah Harkness. While admittedly more liberal than, say, *Twilight*, *True Blood* (the HBO series and its antecedent, The Southern Vampire book series), which often uses vampirism as an allegory for the struggle of LGBT folk, revolves around a telepathic white waitress, Sookie Stackhouse, the object of practically every character's desire, and her vampire beau, Bill Compton, a former Confederate soldier and plantation owner. Harkness's novel features a witch (who is also a professor) falling in love with an enigmatic vampire. *Washington Post* reviewer Elizabeth Hand likened the novel to *Twilight*, dismissing the Harkness work as depicting "yet another unconsummated affair between a mortal (though supernatural) woman and a hot, smoldering-eyed vampire" (2011).
6. That is not to say that Afrofuturism is a late twentieth-century phenomenon, for as Lisa Yaszek masterfully outlines, "The past two decades have been marked by an explosion of interest in literary representation of science and technology. These studies tend to follow a very specific and very raced trajectory: they tell us that white authors including T. S. Eliot, Thomas Pynchon, and William Gibson are the real founders of modern technocultural narrative and that authors of color did not engage in this kind of storytelling until identity politics exploded in the 1960s. . . . But this just isn't true! By recovering Afrodiasporic future story telling traditions we gain a better understanding

of the important intellectual and aesthetic work that these authors have performed on both national and global cultural fronts" (2006).

7. While Dery's definition is a useful point of departure, it is important to acknowledge that in addition to African American speculative-fiction writers, writers and artists of African descent from across the diaspora, such as Nalo Hopkinson, are engaged in similar projects. Furthermore, Afrofuturist themes are found not only in literature but also in music (examples are the artists Sun Ra and Outkast), film (*Black Orpheus* and *Born in Flames*), and art (Jean-Michel Basquiat and Nettrice Gaskins). Other Afrofuturist works include George Schuyler's *Black No More*, Ralph Ellison's *Invisible Man*, and Colson Whitehead's *The Intuitionist*; the music of Jimi Hendrix, Janelle Monae, and Erykah Badu; and films such as *Enemy Mine* and *The Brother from Another Planet.*
8. Microexpressions are brief involuntary facial expressions that denote basic emotions, usually during periods of stress or anxiety. Because they are involuntary, microexpressions are difficult to fake.
9. Butler asserts that a large part of the Ina's allure is the promise of never being alone, one that is instantiated by the addiction to Ina venom. Theodora, a middle-aged white woman, eventually becomes Shori's symbiont despite being somewhat disappointed that Shori is not the vampire of her fantasies—that is, "a tall, handsome fully grown white man" (91). Although Theodora is disabused of this traditional trope of vampire lore, she accepts Shori and recognizes that Shori is offering, besides physical pleasure, companionship and emotional intimacy as well. Theodora admits, "I am lonely. . . . Or I was until you came to me that first time. You've made me feel more than I have since I was a girl. . . . You need me. . . . No one else does, but you do" (92). Brook, who lives as Iosif's symbiont for twenty-two years, admits that she too willingly accepted her Ina companion: "I thought I had finally found a way to avoid all that pain—a way never to be alone again" (110). Although mutualism seems to be an answer for the physical and emotional needs of both humans and vampires, Butler insists that one reason mutualism is fragile is that, ultimately, these situations are not permanent, which should not be too surprising, considering that Butler's mantra from the Parable series is "God is Change." Indeed, a recurrent theme throughout Butler's oeuvre is that change is the only constant.
10. The heading of this section is a hashtag for online black feminist community Quirky Black Girls. See http://quirkyblackgirls.blogspot.com/.

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